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February 4, 2026

Distinguished Teaching Awards Selection Committee

Dear Selection Committee Members,

We write in strong support of Shervin S. Nia's nomination for the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. As his co-advisors in the Department of Chemistry and Biochemistry, we have directly supervised Shervin's teaching and mentorship over multiple quarters. We can attest without reservation that he exemplifies the award's core values: a sustained pattern of effective, evidence-based teaching; incorporation of best practices such as student-centered and inclusive approaches; inspiration of intellectual curiosity; and meaningful support for the success of all students in challenging, high-enrollment STEM courses.

Shervin treats teaching as a core professional responsibility, not a secondary obligation. This dedication shines through in his consistently outstanding student evaluations across terms. Students describe him as exceptionally approachable, patient, and skilled at demystifying complex material. Comments frequently highlight not just knowledge gains, but a welcoming, respectful environment that encourages participation from diverse learners—key elements of inclusive teaching.

Shervin's creativity further distinguishes him. Recognizing a common barrier in introductory biochemistry—students' difficulty translating 2D textbook images into accurate 3D biomolecular understanding—he developed an innovative interactive website featuring visualizations, models, and augmented reality tools. This student-centered resource bridges conceptual gaps, promotes active learning, and has directly improved comprehension and engagement. His technical investment and pedagogical intent reflect best practices in addressing learning barriers through innovative, accessible tools.

This impact extends beyond his sections. Shervin has generously shared his visualization approach with our research group, enabling colleagues to adopt it for scientific posters, outreach events, and public science communication. He also contributes to course forums and peer mentoring, consistently seeking opportunities to enhance understanding and foster equity in learning environments.

In summary, Shervin Nia embodies the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award through rigorous, empathetic, and innovative teaching that inspires students, incorporates evidence-based methods, and promotes inclusive success. We enthusiastically recommend him and are confident he will continue elevating UCLA's educational mission.

Please contact us if further details would assist the committee.

Sincerely,



Z. Hong Zhou, PhD
Founding Director & Professor, Electron Imaging Center for Nanosystems, CNSI/MIMG, UCLA



Matthew Mecklenburg, PhD
Director, Electron Imaging Center for Nanosystems, CNSI, UCLA

Shervin Nia

February 4, 2026

UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award

Self-statement

My teaching at UCLA has been shaped by a simple, persistent observation: many students enter core biochemistry courses believing the subject is designed to intimidate them. As a TA for three quarters of Chem 153A (Biochemistry: Structure, Enzymes, and Metabolism) and one quarter of Chem 156 (Physical Biochemistry), I have made it my responsibility to interrupt that cycle by building discussion sections that are both welcoming and academically motivating. In large-enrollment, pre-health courses like Chem 153A (typically 500+ students per quarter), students can quickly interpret confusion as evidence they do not belong, disengage, and then fall behind. Having taken Chem 153A during my very first quarter at UCLA as a transfer student, I can anticipate where students tend to get stuck and how hesitant they may feel about asking questions. My goal is for students to leave section feeling capable of learning biochemistry and more confident about their place in STEM.

My first and most consistent accomplishment is cultivating a classroom climate where students feel safe seeking help. I prioritize approachability and psychological safety, so students can ask questions without feeling rushed, judged, or "behind." Students explicitly describe this environment in their evaluations. One student wrote that I "never made anyone feel rushed or intimidated for asking something basic" and that I "created an environment where students felt comfortable approaching" me (Artifact 1A). Another wrote, "I never felt afraid or intimidated to ask… clarifying questions," and thanked me for creating "a very welcoming environment" that also encouraged students to work with each other (Artifact 1B). More recently, a student described me as "always open to questions… extremely approachable… and did not look down on his students," emphasizing that my "patience and knowledge made the whole class digestible" (Artifact 1C).

A second accomplishment is my use of evidence-based engagement strategies that make abstract material feel meaningful. To support persistence and curiosity, I connect course concepts to contexts students already understand. I use real-life analogies (e.g., why dish soap behaves differently than dishwasher detergent), pop culture medical scenarios which can be explained with biochemistry (a case of methemoglobinemia from the hit TV series *The Pitt*), and short historical vignettes from the development of modern biochemistry to show that ideas like enzyme kinetics emerged from real scientific struggles and breakthroughs. I highlight, for instance, Maud Menten's path and obstacles as one of the first Canadian women in biomedical science as an entry point

into our lesson on enzyme kinetics as a real human story with lasting scientific consequences. In other words, these stories help exemplify how scientific knowledge is built by people.

A third accomplishment is designing tools that scale to very large courses. In CHEM 153A, students must understand how hemoglobin's 3D structure drives its function, which is difficult to teach when learners only see static images. I created an augmented reality protein visualization activity so students could interact directly with molecular structure (Artifact 2). This kind of "hands-on" interaction is especially valuable in a course where spatial reasoning is a common stumbling block, and is elegantly simple to implement with the smartphones the students already carry. Students specifically noted that the hemoglobin AR sheet was "very helpful," especially because it showed how the "biochem was broken down in 3D and how it connects" (Artifact 1D).

Finally, I consistently extend support beyond assigned duties to increase equitable access to help in a high-stakes course. I participate heavily in Campuswire to answer questions where all students can benefit and to share resources that encourage long-term learning (Artifact 3). I also help run large midterm review sessions with targeted mini-lectures (for example, protein folding), and I have converted discussion sections into optional office hours on holidays rather than cancelling. Students noticed the difference: one wrote that "during many breaks and holidays" I was the "ONLY TA" who held sections and office hours, which "proved how much [I] cared for the success of students" (Artifacts 1C, additional examples in 1D and 1E). I also support the Learning Assistants by attending their weekly trainings and helping them build confidence in both content and teaching, extending high-quality instruction across the course.

Across multiple terms and courses, my teaching impact is best summarized by the consistent student feedback that section felt welcoming, explanations felt digestible, and support felt reliable.

Shervin Nia

February 4, 2026

UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award

Statement of Teaching

My teaching philosophy begins with a belief that is both simple and consequential: students learn challenging science best when they feel safe enough to be wrong. In high-stakes STEM courses, many students treat confusion as a verdict on their ability rather than as a normal step in learning. When that happens, students stop asking questions, reduce learning to memorization, and disengage precisely when they most need practice and feedback. My goal as a teaching assistant is to lower the emotional barrier to participation so students can practice reasoning openly, develop a durable understanding of complex topics, and leave the course with an appreciation for biochemistry as a subject.

I view psychological safety not as comfort for its own sake, but as a prerequisite for serious thinking. If students fear that a question will reveal ignorance, they avoid the behaviors that produce understanding: asking "why," articulating partial reasoning, and testing ideas out loud as a group. In my teaching, I treat uncertainty as normal and useful. I try to make clear to my students that questions are not interruptions; they are information. They show me where students are starting, what assumptions they are carrying, and what conceptual step would unlock the next idea. I also aim to reward the process, not just the outcome: a student who can explain what they tried, where they failed, and what they are unsure about is already embodying the growth mindset they'll need for lifelong learning.

A second core belief is that biochemistry becomes accessible when it is taught as sense-making rather than as a catalog of facts. Students often assume that success means memorizing pathways, equations, and structures, then reproducing them under time pressure. Memorization has a role, but it is fragile. It breaks the moment a problem changes context. My teaching emphasizes mechanisms and relationships: what changes, why it changes, and how that change propagates across a system.

To support this kind of understanding, I emphasize reasoning steps students can use with versatility. Instead of presenting knowledge as finished products, I try to model how experts arrive at conclusions: identify the relevant principle, make a prediction, check it against constraints, and revise when the prediction fails. Quantitative intuition belongs in this framework, but only insofar as it clarifies the story. Numbers should sharpen explanation, not replace it. Albert Einstein, quoting a "wit" he agreed with, captured the spirit of this question: "Education is that which remains, if one has forgotten everything he learned in school." I take this to be my guiding principle in educating my students.

Once my students forget the fine details of this class, what should remain? Ideally, what remains for students is a set of transferable habits of mind: the ability to move between different representations of the same idea (words, graphs, and pictures) without getting lost; the instinct to ask what physical features of a molecule make it behave the way it does; and the confidence to treat quantitative information as a tool for reasoning rather than as a test of math.

A third pillar of my teaching is that relevance creates attention, and attention enables learning. Many students enter biochemistry with key motivations: grades, prerequisites, professional goals. Those motivations are real, but they are often not enough to persevere through difficulty. I encourage students to develop a more sustainable motive: genuine curiosity. One way I do this is by integrating the history of science into course material, not as trivia, but as crucial context that science is built by people, and that confusion and revision are part of the process. Scientific ideas were not delivered fully formed; they were argued over, tested, misunderstood, corrected, and sometimes resisted by countless people. When students hear even brief vignettes of discovery, they begin to see that confusion and iteration are not signs of failure, they are the method.

Teaching in very large courses has shaped how I think about equity and impact. In a class of hundreds, small barriers become large outcomes. If expectations are unclear, confusion scales. If students do not know where to ask questions, silence scales. A large-course mindset pushes me to design learning experiences that are legible, structured, and broadly accessible, without flattening the intellectual challenge. My goal is to create multiple on-ramps to the same high standards: clear reasoning frameworks for everyone, and timely encouragement for students who are anxious, uncertain, or isolated. Across these commitments, I think of the teaching assistant's role as three overlapping identities: translator, guide, and coach. A translator unpacks complex ideas into easier steps. A guide helps students navigate what matters, why it matters, and how ideas connect. A coach builds confidence through practice, reflection, and the normalization of setbacks.

In sum, my teaching philosophy is to create inclusive rigor: a learning environment where students feel safe enough to participate fully and challenged enough to grow. Beyond course content, I want students to leave with durable skills: being confidently inquisitive, articulating reasoning, and approaching unfamiliar problems with method rather than panic. Most of all, I want them to feel that they belong in scientific spaces, not because they don't struggle, but rather they recognize that struggle is part of how scientific understanding is built.

Shervin Nia

February 4, 2026

UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award

Teaching Artifacts

Artifact 1: Teaching evaluations

Artifact 1A: Student comments describing a discussion environment where questions felt safe and welcome, with an emphasis on approachability and reducing intimidation around "basic" questions.

Shervin is easily one of the best and strongest TAs I've had at UCLA. He took a subject that can feel overwhelming and made it clear, organized, and digestible. His sections were always a delight to attend! he was always intentional with his explanations. he walked through the reasoning, pointed out where students commonly get confused, and walked us thru the problems, pointing out what we the professor generally may be looking for in an exam. He was also extremely approachable. Even when his room was packed with students, he made sure everyone's questions were heard and answered. He never made anyone feel rushed or intimidated for asking something basic. His patience and willingness to re–explain concepts was something I really appreciated during a fast–paced course. I also appreciated how he consistently stayed after every lecture to clarify our questions, even when he clearly had a full schedule.

What really stood out about Shervin was his kindness. He treated students with genuine respect, and it was evident he cared about our success beyond just biochemistry. He was supportive when we asked about academic paths, gave thoughtful advice, and created an environment where students felt comfortable approaching him, even those who were normally too nervous to ask questions in class. and I believe this is what makes him stand out from other instructors and assistants.

Overall, Shervin significantly improved my experience in this class. His teaching style, clarity, and genuine care for student learning made a difficult course feel manageable. I'm genuinely grateful for his support this quarter, and future students will be incredibly lucky to have him as their TA.

Artifact 1B: Two separate student comments (separated by a page break) highlighting that the section felt welcoming and low-intimidation, and that the tone encouraged students to ask clarifying questions and participate.

- I know this is Shervin's first time TA-ing, and he is doing a fantastic job and I think many students would agree!! I'm really grateful to be part of Shervin's discussion section. He is really knowledgeable and

passionate about biochemistry, and it is reflected in his teaching during section. He's very kind and open to any and all questions that students have whether it is course content related or career/future related. I never felt afraid or intimidated to ask him clarifying questions, so I'm thankful that he created a very welcoming environment for discussion and encouraged students to also work with each other.

Thank you for being such an amazing TA!

- Shervin is a fantastic TA who knows the material very well. He explains difficult concepts in a way that is easier to understand and is always willing to provide extra clarification and support. I have always felt comfortable coming to him for help or just to ask for advice on how to do better in class. I appreciate how helpful he is. I would definitely have him as a TA again or even as a professor.

Artifact 1C: Student feedback emphasizing respectful treatment and patience, noting that the combination of clarity and kindness made difficult material feel more manageable.

Shervin is probably one of the best TAs I've had at UCLA. He is clearly passionate about student learning, and whether it is a natural talent or not, has continued to develop himself as an educator and support system for students despite how much praise he already gets. Our sections were more difficult this quarter because the content on our worksheets had not been covered in lecture, and I believe if I had any other TA, they would not have supplemented and supported my learning as much as Shervin did. He explained topics in a way that prepared me to not just do the worksheet but come into lecture more than just prepared. As a double Bruin, he really empathized with our struggles and always went above and beyond in not just validating our concerns but helping us figure them out. In many of the topics covered in this course, Shervin provided tips that caused his students to be far more prepared than others, and it showed in peer–to–peer sessions and Campuswire discussions. He also provided many resources, some of them self–made, that expanded on our learning and forged deep understanding. These materials were not just isolated to his discussion sections but provided to the whole class. In addition, during many breaks and holidays, Shervin was the ONLY TA who held discussion sections and office hours, proving just how much he cared for the success of students. He was always open to questions, extremely approachable inside and outside of class, and did not look down on his students. He approached us with the knowledge of a PhD candidate but the kindness of a peer, and I wish all TAs could emulate him. Although the class was a struggle, I think Shervin was the sole reason for how manageable it was and for my predicted success in this course. This is not hyperbole. I often came into discussion without a clue on what was happening, but his patience and knowledge made the whole class digestible, and I found myself recalling his explanations and tips during every exam. I sincerely hope that no matter where he goes, education is a part of it because that is how significant of an impact he had on me.

Artifact 1D: Student comment describing the hemoglobin augmented reality handout as particularly helpful for visualizing concepts in 3D and connecting structure to course ideas.

Our section was fairly early in the week and during it we'd work on the homework in groups. Sometimes large portions of the homework wouldn't yet be covered in lecture. Shervin was excellent at selecting parts of the homework that would be challenging/that we had the info to understand on a basic level and would further explain concepts to us to have a strong enough basis to approach the question without giving us the answer. He would then go around class checking in on groups to see how they're doing and was amazing at guiding us through the problem and providing hints as needed without giving the answer away. And biochem is not easy to break down. There was also a hemoglobin AR sheet he provided us shortly before a test that he'd made himself and it was very helpful as it was significantly tested on the exam and showed us how the biochem was broken down in 3D and how it connects. It was really helpful to see a bit more practically than just in words how everything worked together and demonstrated concepts we continued to use. His office hours were consistent and at accessible times and he was active on the Campuswire to answer student questions. Also, during Thanksgiving week when discussions were cancelled, he was the only TA whose sections were held optionally on that Tuesday. Overall, he's a super accessible and friendly TA who breaks down biochem well and gives us practically perfect material and structure to boost our learning. He also continuously went above and beyond to provide us as much support as possible for those seeking it. I genuinely feel like I lucked out with choosing this section and this TA.

Artifact 1E: Student feedback noting exceptional availability and commitment to student success, including maintaining learning support during breaks/holidays when many students lose access to help.

I think Shervin is my favorite TA I have had at UCLA across all the courses I have taken. He is very open and friendly and I never felt embarrassed to ask questions that might be basic knowledge just to check up because he creates a very comfortable environment in section and I never feel shy. Also he is very patient and is always open to my questions after lecture and will also always have an answer for me so I feel confident that the information and help I am getting is accurate and reflects the class and how Dr. Lannan wants us to learn the content. He is also the only TA that held sections on days where they were cnacelled due to holiday and the only TA that consistently attends lectures. I know that isn't a requirement for TAs but the fact that he goes above and beyond for us is amazing and I just think he is wonderful and has guided my understanding and supported me in this course tremendously. His office hours were also always very helpful and I just enjoyed the way he made biochemistry not seem so scary, and during his office hours we would always have students from other sectiosn attending because I think he wa sthe favorite TA across the whole class, which I understand, but this gave him more "work" in a way because more students would go specifically to him even if he wasn't their TA, but he never turned anyone away and was always happy to help anyone and everyone (literally). He is also very active on campuswire and provides resources for us that he thinks can help our understanding and repsonds to emaisl very prompotly. I just think the amount of time and dedication he puts into this class and us is reflectuve of the type of person he is because he is stil a grad student but goes out of his way to provide resources and guidance for us when he could just do bare minimum and still be amaizng like that.

Artifact 2: Hemoglobin Augmented Reality Activity

I first implemented this interactive activity, shown on the next page, several years ago for the annual Exploring Your Universe outreach event (demo available at bioviewer.net/flyer) as an interactive way for anybody to quickly interact with a protein structure in a 3D manner using their phone. Since then, the IT staff of the California NanoSystems Institute has given me a dedicated web server to host it for any outreach or educational purpose. The next quarter that I taught Chem 153A, the instructor (Dr. Ryan Lannan) was looking for ways to help students visualize the 3D structure of hemoglobin (the protein which delivers oxygen through the blood). I then developed this activity, designed as a two-sided single-sheet handout for students; the QR code on the bottom of the page is printed on the back of each of the four markers. It includes the history of hemoglobin, with a QR code to the original publication of these structures in 1983. To demo this activity: scan the QR code on the bottom of the following page using your phone, accept the prompts on the website, and then point your camera towards the four markers.

Chemistry 153A Hemoglobin Augmented Reality Activity

Visit structures.cnsi.ucla.edu/hemo on your phone or scan the QR code on the back of the page. When you get to the site, scan the markers below to view augmented reality models of deoxygenated human hemoglobin, its heme group and surrounding residues, and its alpha and beta subunits.

These structures were solved by Max Perutz and his colleagues in 1984 (scan the code to the right to check out the paper!). Perutz won the Nobel Prize in 1962 for solving the first protein structure (myoglobin from whale heart) which essentially started the field of protein structural biology.

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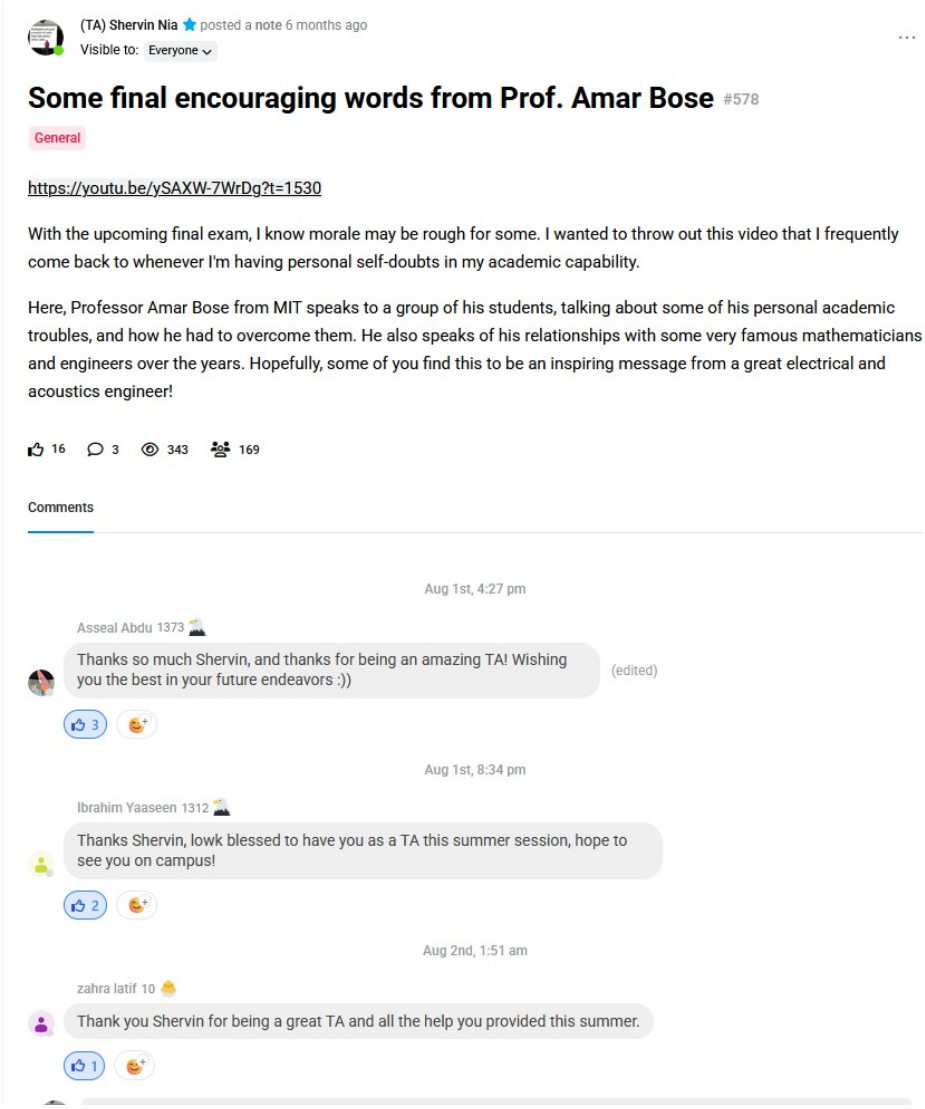






Artifact 3: Campuswire forum posts

Here I post a favorite lecture of mine from Dr. Bose, MIT professor and founder of Bose Corp. I first saw this lecture during my undergrad years and frequently return to it, so I typically use it as my farewell post to the class shortly before their final exam. On the right is a close-up of my profile, where I opted for a lighthearted joke to help break the ice.





Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name Predita Nowrouzi

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

I took Chem153A during the fall 2025 quarter at UCLA, where Shervin was my teaching assistant. I worked consistently with him throughout the quarter in discussion sections, office hours, and course lectures as an actively engaged student.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Shervin inspired students by creating an environment where we felt welcome to participate. He consistently acknowledged that confusion was a natural part of learning and encouraged us to ask questions and share ideas without fearing judgment. This mindset was impactful for those who may otherwise hesitate to engage, helping them remain involved rather than discouraged when concepts became challenging. He also challenged us to think more critically and cooperatively. Rather than immediately providing answers, he directed students to talk through problems together. He prioritized reasoning over rushed responses, encouraging us to articulate our thought processes even if we were unsure. This helped establish our confidence in our ability to work through unfamiliar problems independently. The focus he places on discussion and participation developed our critical thinking skills and emphasized the notion that learning is an iterative, shared process. His calm, supportive presence made difficult concepts feel approachable, while his enthusiasm motivated students to challenge themselves. Many students gravitated toward his office hours because he created a supportive space where learning felt accessible and productive for everyone. After his sections, I frequently felt more assured in the material and my ability to reason through problems independently.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Shervin's greatest strength was his ability to adapt his teaching to meet students where they were. He recognized that students come into biochemistry with different levels of preparation and learning styles, so he made the effort to explain the material in inclusive ways. He led the first discussion of the week, so Shervin would often introduce and walk us through new material before we encountered it in lecture. This early exposure made lectures far more effective and lowered the intimidation and overwhelm we felt when first encountering complex topics. What set his teaching apart was how he used interactive approaches to make abstract ideas easier to understand. A standout example was his use of digital protein models of globins allowing us to visualize three-dimensional structures and understand the relationship between function and structure of proteins. This approach improved our understanding ahead of midterms. Beyond instructional methods, Shervin prioritized accessibility by being consistently available. He stayed after sections taking the time to resolve confusion after lectures, was the only TA to attend review sessions before exams, and even held office hours and discussions during holidays when campus was closed. His commitment ensured students had every opportunity to seek help and succeed.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Shervin goes far beyond the responsibilities of a teaching assistant. He stands out for his unwavering commitment to accessibility, inclusivity, and student success. He takes time to offer guidance on future goals, helps you explore research, and assists with course planning. He is incredibly generous with his time, enthusiastic for teaching, and invested in his students' growth. He is an exceptional instructor but an even more remarkable mentor and human being. He ensures you feel supported, capable, motivated, and educated. His dedication to his role as a teaching assistant makes him an outstanding and highly deserving candidate for this award.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name Ria Casas

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

I know Shervin as my Teaching Assistant for Chemistry 153A, where he was a constant source of guidance for both course content and a mentor in which he provided advice and information about possible futures in STEM.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Shervin is genuinely the best TA I have had at UCLA. I have always struggled with chemistry and performed poorly in organic chemistry, the prerequisites for this course, so I entered biochemistry expecting it to be nearly impossible. It was easy to feel overwhelmed and discouraged early on, but Shervin quickly became a constant source of guidance and reassurance. He consistently broke down complex material into manageable concepts and shared outside resources, such as a website he personally created to help visualize proteins. As a former UCLA student, he clearly understood which topics students find most challenging and intentionally handpicked diagrams and examples that made abstract concepts more accessible,

showing that he genuinely cared about our learning and not just our performance. Shervin regularly went far beyond the scope of his TA responsibilities to support students. He hosted discussion sections even on days he was not required to, including Veterans Day, and welcomed students from all sections, not just those officially enrolled in his own. Despite having the day off, he still held office hours after spending the entire day leading discussions to help us prepare for an upcoming midterm, a significant sacrifice as a PhD student.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

One of the most beneficial things Shervin did for student learning was consistently attending lectures so his own knowledge directly aligned with the instructor's material. This was especially important because the professor could be intimidating to approach, and there was often a long line of students after lecture, making it difficult to get questions answered. Because Shervin was always present in lecture, he was able to clarify concepts immediately after lecture and explain exactly what the professor emphasized and expected us to know. This support was particularly significant given the pace of the course, with lectures held four days a week and new material introduced almost daily. Missing or misunderstanding even one lecture could quickly lead to falling behind. Having a TA who was accessible, informed, and prepared made it much easier to stay on track and confident in the material. As a result, I knew many students who actively sought out Shervin's discussion sections and office hours, even if they were not officially enrolled in his section. His ability to make complex concepts digestible, along with his consistent presence and willingness to help, made a meaningful difference in students' confidence, persistence, and overall understanding of the course.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding

candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Shervin is an outstanding candidate for this award because he genuinely cares about his students as both learners and individuals. He created an environment where I felt comfortable asking questions at any level, even ones I could have searched online, without fear of judgment. Beyond academics, Shervin took the time to discuss his experiences in lab research and the PhD program, which helped me understand a new path forward in STEM. That openness and mentorship inspired me and I was able to talk about being overwhelmed for a future in STEM, something I had never experienced with a TA before.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Biochemistry is infamously known as a weeder class for any biological science major. This reputation caused the course to feel insurmountable among the student body; with this mentality, the instructors are as unapproachable as the topic. However, on the first day, I distinctly remember 4 words that tore down this wall:
"I got a C."
To those who are pre-health, grades are a touchy subject. Yet, Shervin was open. He didn't just preach empathy and compassion to students but embodied it. Being a double Bruin majoring in the very subject he barely passed was a testament to perseverance and hard work which inspired students throughout the course. His discussion sections and office hours were often flooded because talking to him felt like speaking with a mentor with a safer and more inclusive classroom for students of all backgrounds.
However, just because he struggled didn't mean he oversimplified. Instead, he knew what aspects to emphasize and often challenged us. He pushed us to go outside the confines of rote memorization and try applying our knowledge instead with thought experiments on practice problems. I genuinely do not see myself having prevailed in biochemistry under the guidance of any other TA besides Shervin.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Shervin's most exceptional trait in teaching is his proactiveness. He doesn't wait for students to ask questions or struggle in silence before helping. Instead, he anticipates and addresses issues well before they become obstacles to student learning. While I was his student, I saw this displayed in two ways.

The first was his structuring of discussion sections. He knew from the start that the times he was assigned were unoptimal. Students received worksheets and practice problems on content not yet covered in lecture. Shervin prepared his own mini-lectures as a result, not just addressing any content gaps but giving us enough of a basis to answer the questions and come prepared to the next lecture.

The second was his creativity. Protein structure is a large part of biochemistry but requires mental visualization, a skill not many have. Shervin, knowing this, created a scannable worksheet to help us understand the structure of the hemoglobin molecule. However, it didn't just take you to a website but created an alternate reality game (ARG) that made the topic interactive and highly engaging. These were ready well before the corresponding lecture and widely disseminated throughout the course, creating a more equitable environment for student success.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Shervin Nia for 2026 Excellence in Teaching Award

I'm excited to nominate Shervin Nia for the 2026 Excellence in Teaching Award for his contributions to student learning at UCLA. I worked with Shervin in Winter 2023, Summer 2025, and Fall 2025 when he was assigned as a teaching assistant for my sections of Chem 153A (introductory biochemistry). As a teaching assistant, Shervin demonstrated remarkable enthusiasm, dedication, and leadership – receiving significant positive feedback from his students as well as those who worked under him. For myself I would say with confidence that Shervin is one of the strongest teaching assistants I've ever worked with, and an invaluable part of my teaching team when I have the pleasure of working with him.

Students and learning assistants have a lot of kind things to say about Shervin – discussions are a space where he's able to excel. Students often describe him as a "great TA" or "one of the best TAs they've had", highlighting his deep knowledge, approachability, engaging teaching style and personal investment in their learning. He's credited with being able to take "a subject that feels overwhelming" and making it "clear, organized, and digestible". Shervin also fosters an inclusive and welcoming classroom environment, making students feel comfortable asking questions and participating in group discussions. The learning assistants that worked with Shervin appreciated how he found ways to integrate them into discussions properly and felt he had a strong balance between group work and lecturing in a way that made the classroom function smoothly.

Shervin was also a positive presence in team meetings as well as one-on-one conversations. He was always eager to help out, giving 100% in review sessions and during exam proctoring. When asked to assist with a task he was reliable, and turned in work on time. He was a strong grader who understood the nuances of partial credit and was someone who was capable of engaging with the wide variance of student responses. He also (independently) developed supplemental materials for students, most notably a worksheet that projects AR visualizations of various protein structures. This innovation has had lasting impacts on the way we run discussion sections and on the way we teach Chem 153A. In Fall 2025 he, as a veteran TA, effectively took on the role of head TA, effectively becoming an invaluable right hand. He assisted me effectively during TA meetings by providing advice to newer TAs as well as providing resources we had used in previous iterations of the course. If something needed to get done there was no one else I'd rather have taking care of it.

Shervin's impact on student learning and his exceptional ability to connect with and support students make him an ideal candidate for this award. His dedication to teaching is not only

recognized but deeply appreciated by those he has taught (as well as myself). It is with great confidence that I recommend Shervin Nia for the 2026 Excellence in Teaching Award.

Sincerely,



Ryan Lannan, PhD
Lecturer
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